Does *decolonisation* have a definite beginning and end?

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Introduction

Here, decolonization is defined as the process by which colonial rule comes to an end. However, this definition remains ambiguous. What exactly constitutes colonial rule? Does it refer merely to the political and territorial control exercised by colonial powers, or does it encompass something more? Does it refer to the colonial power's dominance in various facets related to a nation-state? The process of colonization leaves a lasting impact on various dimensions of culture, economy, and politics. The colonial dependencies (the territories getting colonised) then usually go through the struggle of removing this "colonial rule" from these different facets of nation building. Is this *decolonisation*? This paper will talk about the different ways several authors have understood and analysed decolonisation (and thus what is meant by "colonial rule") in further discussion. "Colonial rule" itself has now started being related to other phenomena like *Eurocentrism* and various *transnational companies* being set up in post-colonial regions.

So, now comes the question of whether decolonisation has a definite end and beginning? Here again comes the problem of how one understands decolonisation. Different understanding will obviously have different answers to the question. The term has "a plethora of meanings, ambiguities, conflicting memories, and competing narratives" (Osterhammel & Jansen, 2017, p. viii). Hence, it then becomes important to address this question with respect to the different understandings and aspects of decolonisation and understand these variations of decolonisation. This paper talks about the two broad categories in which *decolonisation* is understood: as a *moment* and as a *process.* It also expands on the political economic and cultural aspects of *decolonisation* when we understand it as a process. The main point of discussion in these different understanding of *decolonisation* will be the associated temporal scope: that is when did it *begin* and when did it *end* if it ever did.

Understanding Decolonisation

The term *decolonisation* describes the powerful process of the dissolution of the dominance of an empire like power structure (originally formed usually through colonialism). This process has been defined in various ways by different works discussing the same. So, it becomes important to formalise what we are actually referring to while using this term. Authors like Rober Delavignette (1977) and David Gardinier (1967) understood decolonisation to be a particular global scale political moment, where colonial dependencies "shot up like volcanic lava" (Delavignette, 1977) and replaced the European empires with their own sovereign (usually during the short 30-year period after the second world war). There exists another understanding where the term refers to the multi-faceted process a nation-state undergoes to separate itself from the alien colonial practices in political, economic and cultural institutions of the country. This understanding was championed by several authors like Fanon (1961), Ngũgĩ (1986), Cabral (1974) and Smith (1999). These two aspects are related in the fact that they fundamentally focus on the *undoing* of colonialism. The scope of this *undoing* is what varies in the two understandings.

Understanding *Decolonisation* as a moment

Decolonisation is reduced to the isolated change of the ruler in a country, from a colonial power to something *anticolonial.* This understanding provides us with a pragmatic answer to the question of when decolonisation of a region culminates: when a locally formed government gets full responsibility of the region. The same goes for the question of when the decolonisation of a region started: it is simply when the colonial ruler decides to step down. There was diversity across territories in the way this transfer of power proceeded. There were violent struggles for decolonisation in territories like Vietnam, Algeria and Kenya. Vietnam's decolonisation was marked by the first Indochina War between the nationalists and French

colonial forces (1954). Algeria's decolonisation *moment* occurred after the 8 year long Algerian War of Independence (1962). Kenya experienced the Mau Mau uprising, a violent rebellion against the British colonial rule (1963). In some cases, like India, Ghana and Malaysia decolonisation occurred through negotiations. While India underwent the extremely violent partition, the transfer of power itself was negotiated peacefully between the British authorities and Indian leaders like Nehru and Gandhi (1947). Mobilising public opinion by Kwame Nkrumah and other leaders helped in securing independence without large scale violence in Ghana, transfer of power proceeded through constitutional reforms and political negotiations with Britain (1957). The Federation of Malaya Agreement in 1957 established self-governance without significant armed conflict in Malaysia. There also existed an *accelerated* form of decolonisation, where there is an abrupt transfer of power without a gradual transition or establishing of strong institutional foundations, there appeared to be little pressure of decolonisation until it happened. Accelerated decolonisation occurred in territories like Congo. The Leopoldville riots in 1959 acted as the catalyst to Congo's independence, and in 1960 the king of Belgium handed over power to the government of the Democratic Republic of Congo.

Hence with this understanding, decolonisation becomes a moment that can be captured precisely in historic time. Osterhammel and Jansen (2017) explaining the merits of understanding decolonisation as a moment state that:

> These snapshots offer historians a useful vantage point. One can investigate how the colonial power and the colony arrived at this turning point and, looking into the future, inquire into what became of the dramatic replacement of a coercive political order with the institutions and the spirit of independence and freedom. (p. 14)

The temporal scope of this understanding becomes very clear, even though this moment (and why this moment occurred) varied across regions, it can be said that decolonisation is the definitive rupture in the colonial relationship of a nation-state.

Understanding *Decolonisation* as a process

Decolonisation is seen as much more complex process where it is described as the end of colonial rule or influence over all aspects related to a nation-state, in a way it gets extended into processes of establishing political, economic and cultural sovereignty. This understanding expands both the temporal scope and the dimensions associated with decolonisation.

Political Decolonisation

The process of undoing colonialism in political institutions is more or less complete in all territories that were colonised. On 9th May of 2024, only 17 non-self-governing territories remain colonised and are on the agenda of C-24 (Special Committee of Decolonisation). These regions like Gibraltar, Anguilla and Pitcairn are usually small area low population regions whose inhabitants usually don't feel a strong urge toward a full national self-government. This political change started when resistance increased. Resistance to colonial rule grew when the major colonial states lost their status as "Great powers". British was significantly weakened due to its wealth getting depleted in the second world war and also it losing control over its far east territories. France was defeated and much of its colonial empire was overrun. There was also a discourse brewing in the metropolitan population of Europe about the purposes of a colonial empire. Along with this Betts (2012) claims:

> as Europe recovered from the war, the colonial powers increasingly vested their interests in their own continent, faced on the east by the Soviet Union and the west by the United States, the two superpowers of the new era, both publicly opposed to the

> colonial empires. The defensive treaty NATO (1949) was one clear indication of a new European cooperation, distinguished from the former colonial rivalry. (p. 26)

The formation of the United Nations in 1945 also added to the debate of decolonisation, in 1960 the Declaration on Decolonization of Granting Independence to Colonial Countries and People was adopted by the General Assembly of the United Nations. It asserted that 'an end must be put to colonialism'. Following this, many colonies gained independence in the 1960s and 1970s, including Nigeria (1960), Kenya (1963), and Angola (1975), marking the decline of direct colonial rule across much of the world. The temporal scope of this *decolonisation* then becomes the thirty-year period after the second world war, where most colonial powers gave up control over territories and newly established locally formed governments took over.

Economic Decolonisation

After achieving political independence, most previously colonised nations adopted the colonial economic institutions. Even though the colonial powers always altered the pre-existing economic structures, there was hardly any national movement that aimed at reversing these changes. In some cases, the colonial economic and infrastructural development could not be sustained by the newly independent territories, but this was usually not an intended effect of the new anti-colonial ideas and policies being implemented. Rather almost all nations wanted to embrace the newer economic structures formed by colonialism and place these structures under their own national management. New nation-states usually strived for modernity or adopted for (not indigenous) economic structures like socialism. This was motivated by the theory that "only a prospering national economy could guarantee the strongest possible international standing for the fragile new state." (Osterhammel & Jansen, 2017). As many territories gained independence, the trade patterns became industry centred, as countries like the US, Japan and most of western Europe prospered after the second world

war. Yansané (1980, pp. 287-9) argues that the middle class of the new nation-states "allowed transnational corporations to gain control of local economies and to make them part of ongoing globalization". In West Africa, British firm like United Africa Company and Barclays Bank continued in Ghana and Nigeria, these firms incorporated indigenous managers but had to face national policies which made them transfer assets to local owners. In Kenya, multinational corporations dominated sectors like agriculture and trade. The Kenyan economy remained tied to foreign capital. Chinese companies like Huawei infiltrated the African and Latin American markets, hence this gave rise to a new type of colonialism. This argument lets us take a look at the widely discussed theory of *neocolonialism.* Neocolonialism subscribes to the idea that European/American powers are economically exploiting indigenous nation-states through mediums like powerful multinational corporations rather than direct domination over a state. Some even view *decolonisation* as a strategy of nation states to retain global influence by shielding itself from international interference and scrutiny. Fanon (1961) in his famous work *"The wretched of the earth"* states that the middle class acted as a "the transmission line between the nation and a capitalism" (p. 152) and that "The national bourgeoisie will be quite content with the role of the Western bourgeoisie's business agent" (p. 153).

So how did the process of the *decolonisation* of the economy start? It has its roots in the shared grievances against the nature of economic activities under colonial rule/influence: high taxes, condition of workers, rampant exploitation of natural resources, suppression of indigenous business. But are harsh working conditions worse than having no job at all? Is exploitation of resources worse than living in sparse conditions? These questions give rise to another important root of economic decolonisation: consumerism. Pioneered by Mahatma Gandhi, economic decolonisation strived to get rid of the contamination that happened through Western materialism and consumerism. Gandhi promoted homespun cloth to counter

British textiles, he viewed Western civilisation's materialism as inherently violent, advocating for simplicity and non-possession to dismantle colonial economic systems. The process of political decolonisation can simply be confined to the sequence of events which led to the beginning of self-government and its homemade laws being exercised. The temporal scope of economic decolonisation cannot be as well defined as that of political decolonisation. Only in a minority of cases has the nation-state aimed at complete expulsion and removal of alien and colonial factors from native economic institutions. Economic decolonisation followed political decolonisation with a certain time lag. In Western Africa and Algeria, there was continued presence of French economic interests, which later reduced due to shift in interests. The British Empire in an effort to maintain the dominance of the pound introduced the "sterling area" which included India, Pakistan etc. Members of this sterling bloc were provided capital aid by the British. The process of economic decolonisation has not been completed as most countries continue to follow the colonial economic structures, with very few signs of transitioning to a newer form of the economy.

Cultural Decolonisation

Ngũgĩ (1986) added that "the biggest weapon wielded and actually daily unleashed by imperialism against that collective defiance is the cultural bomb" (p. 3). This bomb caused the destruction of the culture of indigenous population through imposition of the colonial power's cultural system. The political decolonisation of the 20th century did not automatically erase the system of knowledge decolonisation was based on. The "system of knowledge that was put in place during colonisation and systematically imposed by the colonisers to provide a moral justification for colonisation itself." (Saraceni, 2023, para 7). The justification was that: the coloniser was superior to the colonised, and hence was justified to colonise and also morally obliged to do so.

Based on this principle, the coloniser and the colonised were placed at opposite ends of the civilisation spectrum:

coloniser < – – – > colonised

civilisation < – – – > savagery

religion < – – – > superstition

democracy < – – – > absolute rule

nations < – – – > tribes

literature < – – – > oral tradition

languages < – – – > dialects (Saraceni, 2023, para 8)

Rudyard Kipling (1899) in his work *White Man's Burden* says that it is the duty of a superior white man to civilise the indigenous population that are "Half devil and half child". He wrote this in encouragement of the American annexation and colonisation of the Philippine Islands (1899). American imperialists adopted the phrase "the white man's burden" to justify their imperial conquest.

Figure 1

"The White Man's Burden" illustration

Note: From the Detroit Journal (1898)

In India, cultural imposition occurred through the so called “civilising mission of colonialism”, they claimed that British Raj is the legitimate government of India: British Raj is the “Mai-Baap Sarkar”, like parents protecting and educating an unruly, petulant child. Macaulay’s famous *Minute on Education* advocated for the promotion of English, arguing that “a single shelf of a good European library was worth the whole native literature of India and Arabia” (1835, p. 3). This led to the establishment of English-medium schools and universities, sidelining the pre-existing forms of education systems like Gurukuls. British sought to gain knowledge about the Indian society through religious scriptures, in this process they created a “Hindu tradition” and “Muslim tradition”. Religion and caste were normalised as essence of Indian society. This caused the creation of monolithic social categories based on religion. Everything including History, Philosophy, Kingdoms, Languages, Food, Clothes, Music, Architecture was labelled with religion and caste. Social reforms targeted practices perceived as oppressive, such as sati and child marriage. One’s social identity was solidified and hardened: it became unchanging. Modern day India continues to go through the struggle of reversing this, struggles to *undo* the structures created by colonialism. Communalism and caste-based discrimination persists, the transformation of religions into monolithic hardened religious identities (previously more fluid) causing exacerbation of communal tensions, social segregation and political manipulation. Religious and caste identities are often used as tools for political mobilisation by parties like BJP, Samajwadi Party, Rastriya Janata Dal and so on. Post independence, there has been a conscious effort to revive traditional cultural practices and identities through movements like the Swadeshi movement. But still, the process of cultural decolonisation continues because in a way, it is the *decolonisation of the mind.* For cultural decolonisation to be completed, there will have to be drastic restructuring in the way a massive population thinks and behaves.

Ngũgĩ in his book *Decolonising the mind*, wrote about importance of decolonising African literature, he says that language is “central to a people’s definition of themselves” (1986, p. 4). Hence the medium of communication should be one’s own, not the one that was imposed by the alien forced of colonialism. He called for dethroning of English in favour of African languages. He himself later in his career switched to writing in his native language of Gikuyu. In Africa, “things must be seen from the African perspective” (Ngũgĩ, 1986, p. 94). But with English establishing itself as **the** global language, it has become more inconvenient to switch back to the native language. This predicament gives rise to another argument: the need to reconfigure the world so as, to ‘provincialize’ Europe (Chakrabarty, 2000) and decentre it. Essentially, the world’s Eurocentric mindset had to be eradicated. Removing this Eurocentrism has now been associated with decolonisation. The presence of Eurocentrism in various aspects has been attributed to colonialism. The efforts to decolonise various aspects of human life like education. global health and gender continue.

Cultural *decolonisation* varies drastically from the political *decolonisation* that occurred in the 20th century, this newer form of decolonisation deals with something more complex:

> It’s a long and tortuous process, much more so than replacing one flag with another, or swapping one national for another. It’s a necessity if we are serious about rebalancing a worldview long skewed by colonisation. (Saraceni, 2023, para 9)

Therefore, to assign a beginning to cultural decolonisation it becomes necessary to determine when a nation-state starts adopting a more indigenous system of knowledge that attempts to *undo* the effects of the European system of knowledge. Various such efforts have been made around the world, countries India, South Africa and various Latin American nations have tried to decolonise curricula by including indigenous histories, philosophies and worldviews.

Cultural decolonisation remains an ongoing process where literature and policies attempt to localise the population's behaviour and mind.

Conclusion

The term *decolonisation* hence signifies various different processes and phenomena. For each of these variations, there is a different answer to the question of whether or not it has a definite beginning and end. As discussed, the answer is very clear when we understand decolonisation as a moment. For political decolonisation, the sequence of events can be clearly mapped out. But determining the temporal scope of economic and cultural decolonisation becomes a challenge, as many territories continue to adopt the colonial systems. Modern decolonisation thus deals with

> becoming aware of and rejecting the colonial system of knowledge that still lingers today; then, replacing it with more balanced, complex and locally relevant understandings of human societies and the relationships between them and finally, changing practices as a result (Saraceni, 2023)

This process of decolonisation is still ongoing, one geared towards removing all vestiges of colonialism present in the nation-state.

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